

debut (*Everybody Says I am Fine*, 2001), Irani had been a professional photographer and a theatre actor.

While he was acquiring the skills to become a director, Irani came across the idea that triggered *The Mehta Boys*, thanks to director Sujoy Ghosh. "He told me a one-liner about a father and son who have to spend 48 hours together. At the airport when they are saying goodbye to each other, they realise their follies. He wanted to make the film with me but there was something about the idea I wanted to explore myself. I told him I wanted to direct this story and he very graciously gave it to me."

Irani, who has also produced the film through his Irani Movietone LLP banner alongside his son Danesh Irani, Vikesh Bhutai and Shujaat Saudagar, calls himself "a producer only in name". "I didn't want to complicate my life, so when I had to make decisions as a director, I didn't think like a producer. I wanted to shoot at a real airport but we couldn't. We had very little time at an old convention centre. I told my actor that we had to do the scene in one take simply because we had no time." While directing oneself is never easy, Irani found a method that worked for him. "Once the scene was done, I'd ask my co-actors, 'Should we go and ask the old man what he thought?' I'd sit in the director's chair behind the monitor and become the 'old man' and tell them what I needed," he says with a laugh.

Stepping behind the camera has fulfilled a childhood dream for Irani. And, now that he's directed his first, he can't wait to experience the rush again. "I have four or five ideas and I want to get cracking on them." ■

– Karishma Upadhyay



MASTER OF MANY HATS

Arif Zakaria, who is basking in the success of *Freedom at Midnight*, opens up about playing the historical character of Jinnah, and his upcoming projects

Your portrayal of Mohammad Ali Jinnah in *Freedom at Midnight* has received critical acclaim. How was it getting under the skin of the character?

The preparation was laborious, exciting and gratifying. We were given scripts in advance, so the preparation was structured around readings and getting the tone and physicality right. The director, Nikkhil Advani, was crystal clear about what the characters should embody and enact.

Q. What is your character arc in Neeraj Pandey's upcoming *Special Ops 2.0*?

With a great run in the first season, there is much anticipation for *Special Ops 2.0*. The special task force on behalf of the government undertakes a rescue mission, with my character at the centre of it! It's a high-octane show with its trademark twists and turns.

Q. What was it like being a part of *Bollywood Masala*–a funky musical parody on Bollywood that showed in Paris?

The show, conceived by writer-director Toby Gough, is told through the eyes of a celebrity chef who recounts his experiences feeding some of the biggest stars in Bollywood. It used humour, storytelling and elements of dance to further the narrative. The Parisians loved this unique presentation.

Q. Any other projects in the pipeline?

Besides *Special Ops 2.0*, there's *Freedom at Midnight Season 2* and *The Socho Project* by Abhigyan Jha. I also have two films on the cards–*Heer Sara Aur Pondicherry* by Kartik Chaudhry and *Faraar* by Kushagra Sharma.

–with Geetika Sachdev